

Open era: On the Australian Open

Australian Open this year **marks** more than the start of a new season

Coming as it does at the beginning of a brand new tennis season, the Australian Open is never short of fresh and **intriguing** storylines. The 2025 **edition**, which started on Sunday, **is** no exception. **Of interest** will be Novak Djokovic's **quest** for a record-breaking 25th Major, Jannik Sinner's title defence **amidst** a **doping cloud**, Carlos Alcaraz's search for a **maiden** trophy in Melbourne and Aryna Sabalenka's desire to make it a hat-trick **Down Under**. With his greatest rivals Roger Federer and Rafael Nadal retired, Djokovic is the **lone** representative from the Big Three era. **The 37-year-old**, a record 10-time champion in Australia, **has** not won an ATP Tour-level title since November 2023 and will be looking to three-time Slam winner Andy Murray, who is now his coach, for some fresh solutions as he enters the **last leg** of his career. **Sinner**, who had an otherwise **impeccable** 2024, **awaits** an April hearing at the Court of Arbitration for Sport (CAS) after the World Anti-Doping Agency appealed his **acquittal** by the International Tennis Integrity Agency (ITIA) over two failed dope tests. **Alcaraz**, at 21, **can** become the youngest man to win a career Grand Slam (acquiring all four Majors at least once) while **Sabalenka**, with her fourth Slam, **can cement** her position as the best hard-court player in the world.

With Sinner and Alcaraz having split 2024's Majors equally, the **onus** was on Alexander Zverev and Daniil Medvedev to ensure that their **generation** — **sandwiched** between the times of the Big Three and the Sinner-Alcaraz duopoly — **is** not **squeezed out** in tennis' all-new era. But Medvedev lost on Thursday, leaving Zverev with the responsibility of maintaining their position at the high table. Though the **rungs** are not as clear cut among women, there is **intense jostling** at the top among the **trinity** of Sabalenka, Iga Swiatek and Coco Gauff. Swiatek is a five-time Slam champion but has **gone past** the fourth round at Melbourne Park just once (2022, semifinal). The 23-year-old also has her **aura dimmed** after accepting a month's ban in November for a positive dope test. For the United States' Gauff, a lack of consistency has been her **bane**. But if she can carry her strong recent form — WTA Finals crown in November 2024 and United Cup **triumph** earlier this January — she will be a real force. Unfortunately, Indians are never part of these conversations. Sumit Nagal is already out, losing in the first round, and so are men's doubles **practitioners** Rohan Bopanna — who at the 2024 Australian Open became the oldest man to be No.1 and win a Major — and Yuki Bhambri. **[Practice Exercise]**

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Era** (noun) – Period, age, epoch, time, phase युग
2. **Mark** (verb) – Indicate, signify, commemorate, denote, highlight संकेत करना
3. **Intriguing** (adjective) – Fascinating, captivating, interesting, engrossing, compelling दिलचस्प
4. **Of interest** (phrase) – Relevant, significant, important, noteworthy, appealing रुचिकर
5. **Quest** (noun) – Pursuit, search, journey, mission, expedition खोज
6. **Amidst** (preposition) – Among, surrounded by, in the middle of, during, amidst के बीच में
7. **Doping** (noun) – Drug use in sports, performance-enhancing drug abuse, substance use, illicit drug usage, banned drug intake खेलों में प्रतिबंधित दवाओं का उपयोग
8. **Cloud** (noun) – Shadow, doubt, uncertainty, suspicion, ambiguity संदेह
9. **Maiden** (adjective) – First, initial, inaugural, debut, original पहली बार का
10. **Down Under** (noun) – Australia, ऑस्ट्रेलिया
11. **Lone** (adjective) – Single, solitary, only, unique, isolated अकेला
12. **Last leg** (noun) – Final phase, concluding part, end stage, terminal part, final stretch अंतिम चरण
13. **Impeccable** (adjective) – Flawless, perfect, unblemished, pristine, faultless निर्दोष
14. **Acquittal** (noun) – Exoneration, discharge, clearance, absolution, vindication बरी होना
15. **Cement** (verb) – Strengthen, solidify, fortify, reinforce, stabilize मजबूत करना
16. **Onus** (noun) – Responsibility, duty, obligation, burden, accountability जिम्मेदारी
17. **Sandwich** (verb) – Position between, squeeze between, enclose, press, interpose बीच में फंसाना
18. **Squeeze out** (phrasal verb) – Force out, push out, oust, displace, expel बाहर निकालना
19. **Rung** (noun) – Level, step, position, tier, stage सीढ़ी का पायदान/स्तर
20. **Intense** (adjective) – Fierce, strong, extreme, passionate, vigorous तीव्र
21. **Jostling** (noun) – Competition, tussle, struggle, pushing, contest धक्का-मुक्की/प्रतिस्पर्धा

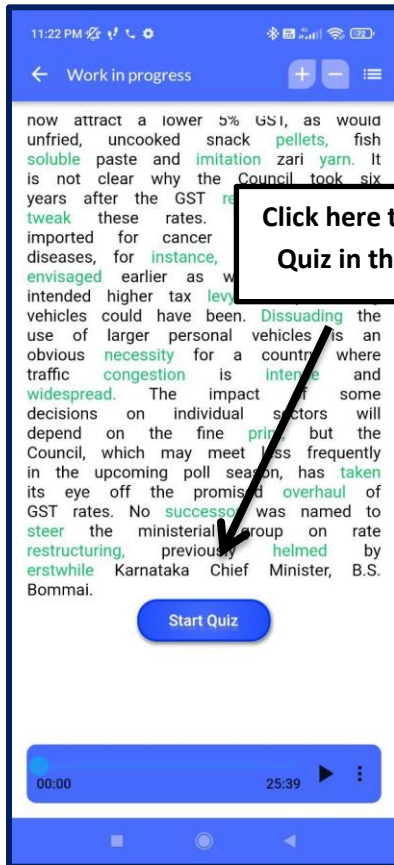
22. **Trinity** (noun) – Trio, triad, threesome, threefold, triumvirate त्रिमूर्ति
23. **Go past** (phrase) – Surpass, exceed, move beyond, progress, advance आगे बढ़ना
24. **Aura** (noun) – Atmosphere, vibe, essence, energy, ambience आभा/प्रभाव
25. **Dim** (verb) – Weaken, dull, lessen, fade, obscure कमजोर करना
26. **Bane** (noun) – Curse, burden, trouble, nemesis, affliction अभिशाप/मुसीबत
27. **Triumph** (noun) – Victory, success, accomplishment, conquest, achievement जीत/सफलता
28. **Practitioner** (noun) – Professional, participant, player, performer, expert विशेषज्ञ/प्रयोगकर्ता

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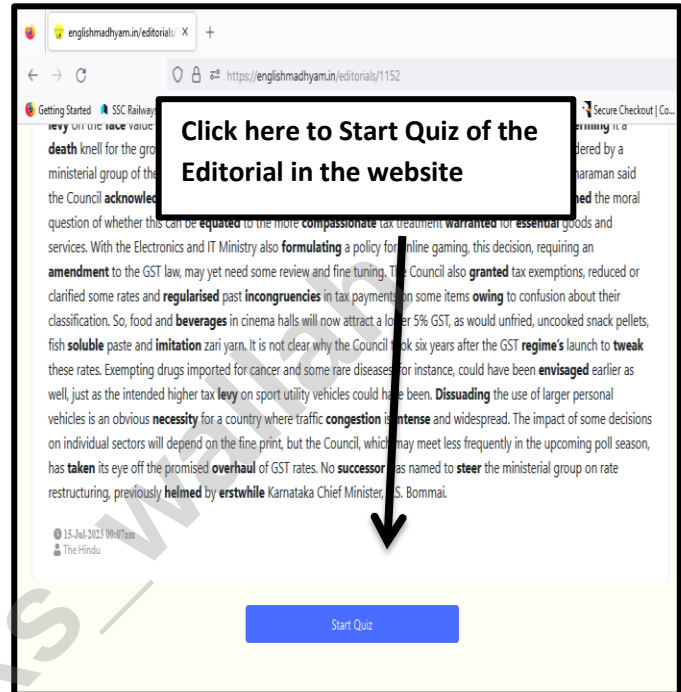
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Start of a New Season:** The Australian Open begins the tennis calendar and is rich with fresh storylines and anticipation.
2. **Novak Djokovic's Quest:** Djokovic aims for his record-breaking 25th Major title, seeking to extend his legacy as the last member of the Big Three era still active.
3. **Jannik Sinner's Title Defence:** Sinner, the defending champion, faces uncertainty due to an impending doping hearing at the Court of Arbitration for Sport (CAS).
4. **Carlos Alcaraz's Ambition:** Alcaraz, at 21, strives to become the youngest man to achieve a career Grand Slam by winning his first Australian Open.
5. **Aryna Sabalenka's Challenge:** Sabalenka aims for her third consecutive Australian Open title, solidifying her dominance on hard courts.
6. **Djokovic's New Approach:** With Andy Murray as his coach, Djokovic seeks innovative strategies as he navigates the final phase of his illustrious career.
7. **Sinner-Alcaraz Rivalry:** The two players, who equally split the 2024 Majors, symbolize the new era of tennis and dominate the current landscape.
8. **Generation Pressure on Zverev and Medvedev:** Sandwiched between the Big Three era and the rise of Sinner-Alcaraz, Zverev and Medvedev face challenges to maintain their relevance. Medvedev's early exit leaves Zverev carrying this burden.
9. **Women's Open Field:** The competition among Aryna Sabalenka, Iga Swiatek, and Coco Gauff highlights an intense battle for supremacy in women's tennis.
10. **Iga Swiatek's Struggles:** Despite being a five-time Slam champion, Swiatek's Melbourne Park record is modest, and her recent doping ban has impacted her reputation.
11. **Coco Gauff's Potential:** Gauff's recent successes, including the WTA Finals and United Cup victories, position her as a strong contender if she maintains consistency.
12. **Indians Missing from Spotlight:** Indian players continue to struggle at the Australian Open, with early exits by Sumit Nagal, Rohan Bopanna, and Yuki Bhambri.
13. **Djokovic's Australian Legacy:** The Serbian remains the most successful player in Australian Open history, with ten titles, and seeks to extend his dominance.
14. **Women's Tennis Rivalries:** Unlike the men's game, women's tennis lacks a clear hierarchy, making the competition more unpredictable.
15. **Changing Tennis Landscape:** The 2025 Australian Open highlights the ongoing transition in tennis, with emerging talents replacing established legends.

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



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